

The following passage from the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*
describes the kind of view I want to discuss:

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, "of both the just and the unjust," will precede the Last Judgment. ... Christ will come "in his glory, and all the angels with him Before him will be gathered all the nations, and he will separate them one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand, but the goats at the left.... and they will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life."

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: is what we are told about life after death by many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a perfectly good God?

Here is what Ted Sider says about this kind of view:

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This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will go to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the talk of the **last** judgement wouldn't make much sense.)

Our lead-in showed why it is plausible that responses to the argument from evil must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of view of life after death we get here compatible with God being perfectly good?



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox

A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "evil & lives not worth living" is written in a white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

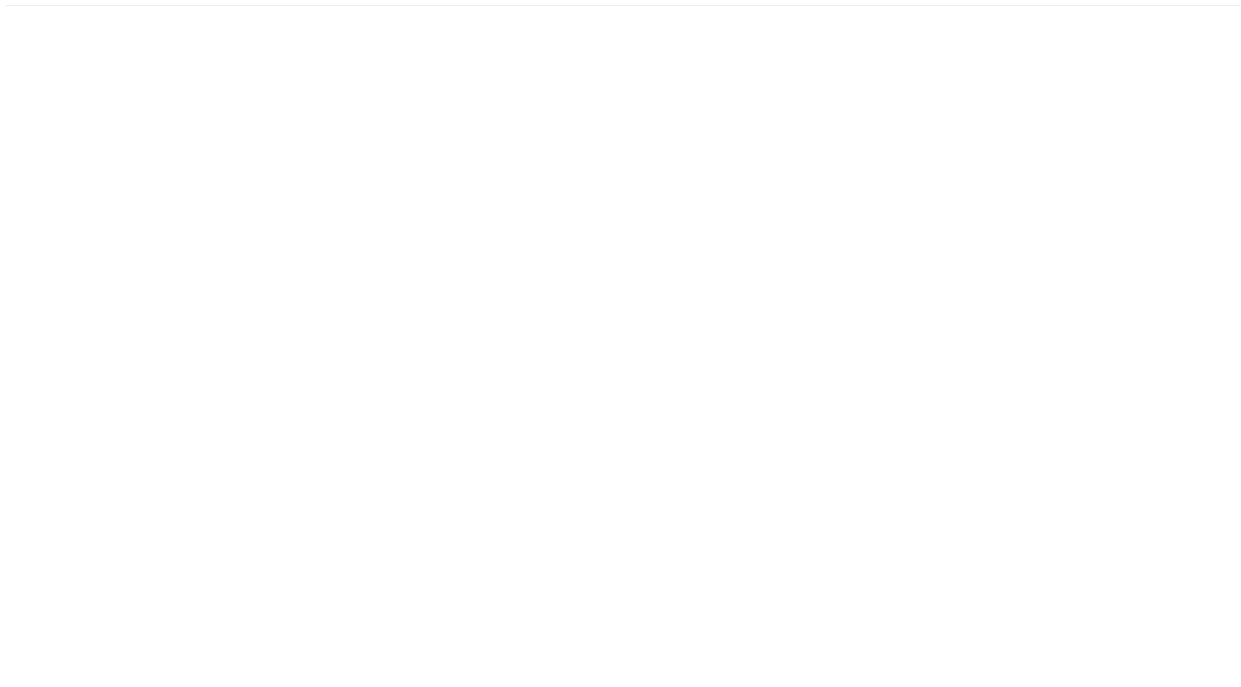
evil & lives
not worth
living

A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is binary. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree.

The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.

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Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

into external punishment, but the rights into

eternity!

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

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another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

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perfectly good Good?



1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

this glory, and all the angels with him . . .

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

and the wild sheep are then from another

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

they will go away into eternal punishment,

but the rights are all in it.

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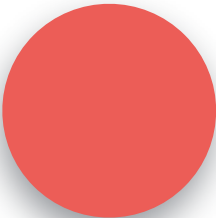
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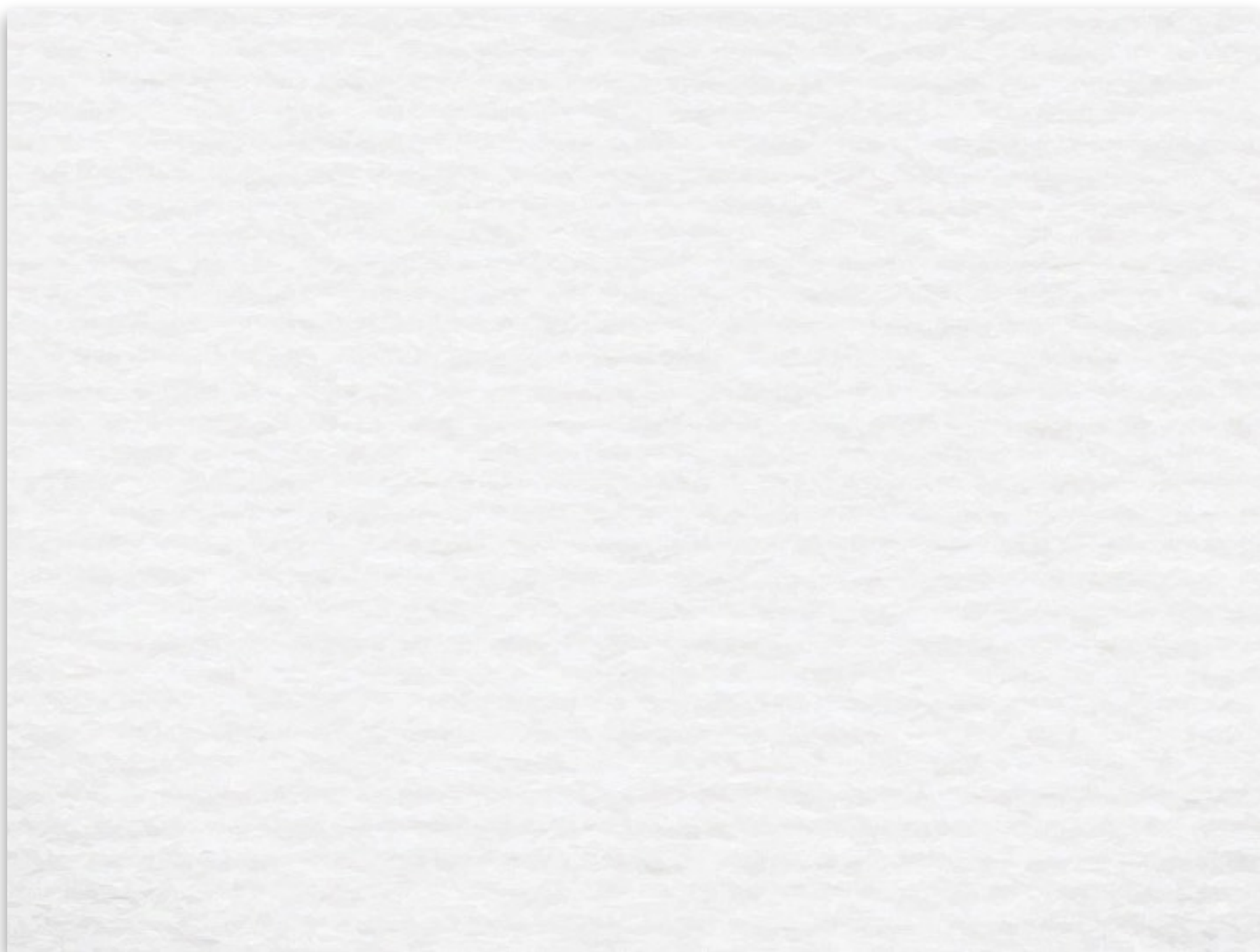
Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?







bad. There are no possibilities for the article

he11. Heaven is very, very good; he11 is very, very

or hell is never in that degree.

other than heaven and hell, and men as in heaven

The problem with the binary conception is that it

Art and architecture in the 19th century

binary. After death, predators with heavier or

criticized and decried which goes to heaven and who goes

people in Heaven. Not just God who said a

to be 1. No reason why

read as a whole. But

treated. Here must therefore be people who

corresponding initials are to be

containing God's justice. God must employ some

the binary representation of the answer is

nearby industries in the area represent

nonstoply unfair thing.

traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

the existence of a perfectly good God.

Let's try to layout Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the

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It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

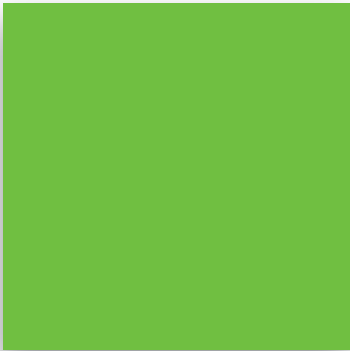
heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,

Let's call them the relevant properties.



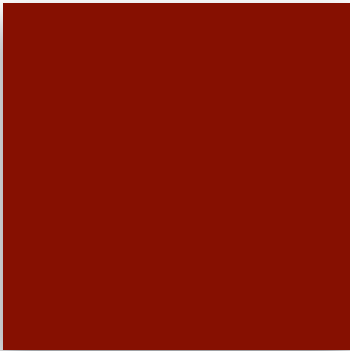














It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.









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